



EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM

WEEK 3 · JULY 25, 2026

# Pulse Diagnosis

## Lecture Primer

FCM Chapter 25 · CAM Chapter 13

Normal Pulse · 28 Classical Pulse Qualities

Yin/Yang Classification · Clinical Groupings

### ⚠ QUIZ 2 · JULY 24, 2026

Covers Week 2 material — Eight Principles, Tongue & Pulse intro

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TCM for Ballroom Dancers | Dance Medicine Specialty

溫故知新 · 온고지신



PRE-LECTURE READING (BEFORE JUL 25)

FCM Chapter 25 — Maciocia: Normal pulse, 28 qualities, clinical groupings, significance of each

CAM Chapter 13 — Cheng Xinnong: Normal pulse, 28 pathological types, pulse-taking method, Yin/Yang groupings

THE NORMAL PULSE — 平脈 Píng Mài

| Quality                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Description                                      | Factor     | Normal Variation                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Rate                                                                                                                                                                                                          | 4–5 beats/respiration (72–80 bpm)                | Season     | Spring: wiry · Summer: flooding · Autumn: floating · Winter: deep |
| Depth                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Middle level — not too superficial, not too deep | Age        | Children: faster · Elderly: deeper, weaker                        |
| Strength                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Forceful but not excessive; soft but not empty   | Gender     | Women: softer; right slightly larger                              |
| Rhythm                                                                                                                                                                                                        | Regular — no skipped or irregular beats          | Build      | Tall: slower · Short: faster · Thin: superficial · Heavy: deeper  |
| <div>Three Essentials 胃神根</div> <div>Wèi 胃 — Stomach Qi: flowing, gentle, harmonious</div> <div>Shén 神 — Spirit: strong, rhythmical, responsive</div> <div>Gēn 根 — Root: deep at Chi; Kidney Qi present</div> |                                                  | Exercise   | Faster, fuller; returns to normal at rest                         |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                  | Emotion    | Fear → rapid · Anger → wiry · Grief → thin                        |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                  | Food/Preg. | Slippery after meals; slippery at Cun in pregnancy                |

PULSE POSITIONS — 寸關尺

| Position   | Cun 寸 (distal)                             | Guan 關 (middle)     | Chi 尺 (proximal)                          |
|------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Left Hand  | Heart / SM Intestine<br>chest, Pericardium | Liver / Gallbladder | Kidney (Yin) / Bladder<br>Lower Jiao (L)  |
| Right Hand | Lung / LG Intestine<br>chest               | Spleen / Stomach    | Kidney (Yang) / Bladder<br>Lower Jiao (R) |

⚠ FLOATING PULSE TRAP (FROM WK 2 — LIKELY ON QUIZ 2!)

Floating ≠ always Exterior. In Yin deficiency (night sweats, five-palm heat, malar flush) → **Floating + Empty = Empty Heat**. Context determines pattern.

28 PULSE QUALITIES — COMPLETE REFERENCE

7 GROUPS TO ORGANIZE YOUR THINKING

Floating · Sinking · Rate · Strength · Width/Shape · Rhythm · Composite — feel the group first, then the specific quality within it

| Pulse (CN/Pinyin)                              | How It Feels                                                      | Clinical Indication                                     | Group / Key Note        |
|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| ► FLOATING GROUP 浮 — felt at superficial level |                                                                   |                                                         |                         |
| Floating 浮 Fú                                  | Easily felt superficially; weakens with pressure                  | Exterior patterns; Yin def (floating + empty)           | ↑ Depth                 |
| Hollow 芤 Kōu                                   | Floating, large, soft — hollow in middle (scallion stalk)         | Loss of Blood or fluids (heavy bleeding, profuse sweat) | ↑ Depth + hollow center |
| Leather 革 Gé                                   | Floating, taut, large, hollow — firm outside, empty inside (drum) | Loss of Jing/Blood; uterine bleeding; seminal emission  | ↑ Depth + hard surface  |
| ► SINKING GROUP 沉 — felt only at deep level    |                                                                   |                                                         |                         |
| Deep 沉 Chén                                    | Only with heavy pressure at bone level                            | Interior patterns; Qi stagnation; pain; Water retention | ↓ Depth                 |
| Firm 牢 Láo                                     | Deep, wiry, forceful; remains hard under pressure                 | Accumulation of Cold; abdominal masses                  | ↓ Depth + hard          |
| Hidden 伏 Fú                                    | Deeper than Deep; felt only at bone with very heavy pressure      | Severe Interior Cold; fainting; extreme pain            | ↓ Depth extremis        |
| ► RATE GROUP — beats per respiration           |                                                                   |                                                         |                         |
| Rapid 數 Shuò                                   | >5 beats/resp (>90 bpm)                                           | Heat (Full or Empty); extreme Qi exhaustion             | ↑ Rate                  |
| Slow 遲 Chí                                     | <4 beats/resp (<60 bpm)                                           | Cold (Full or Empty); Yang deficiency                   | ↓ Rate                  |
| Racing 疾 Jí                                    | Extremely rapid (>7 beats/resp, >120 bpm)                         | Extreme Heat consuming Yin; dying Yang floating upward  | ↑ ↑ Rate extremis       |

| Pulse (CN/Pingin)                    | How It Feels                                                  | Clinical Indication                                         | Group / Key Note            |
|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Moderate 緩 Huǎn                      | 4 beats/resp; even, relaxed; slightly slow                    | Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen Qi def (if weak)      | Normal/Damp                 |
| ► STRENGTH GROUP — force / amplitude |                                                               |                                                             |                             |
| Full / Replete 實 Shí                 | Large, forceful at all three levels; no weakening on pressure | Excess patterns; Full Heat; excess Fire                     | ↑ Force                     |
| Empty / Deficient 虛 Xū               | Soft, weak at all three levels; weakens further on pressure   | Deficiency patterns; Qi/Blood def                           | ↓ Force                     |
| Weak 弱 Ruò                           | Deep, soft, fine; only at deep level with light touch         | Qi and Blood def; Yang deficiency                           | ↓ Force + deep              |
| Frail / Minute 微 Wēi                 | Extremely thin, soft; barely perceptible; nearly absent       | Severe Qi, Yang, Blood def; collapse                        | ↓↓ Force extremis           |
| ► WIDTH / SHAPE GROUP                |                                                               |                                                             |                             |
| Wiry 弦 Xián                          | Taut, tense; like pressing a violin string; long              | Liver/GB patterns; pain; Phlegm; Damp; old age (normal)     | Taut                        |
| Slippery 滑 Huá                       | Smooth, flowing; like pearls rolling on a dish                | Phlegm/Damp; Heat; pregnancy (normal); after meals (normal) | Smooth                      |
| Choppy 澀 Sè                          | Uneven, rough, hesitant; like scraping bamboo with a knife    | Blood stasis; Blood/Fluid def; Jing deficiency              | Rough/Uneven                |
| Flooding 洪 Hóng                      | Large, forceful; rises like a wave then fades                 | Excess Heat; Summer Heat; exertion (normal)                 | Large + wave force          |
| Thin / Fine 細 Xì                     | Thin like a thread; clearly perceptible; not weak             | Blood def; Yin def; Damp (if slippery + thin)               | Narrow width                |
| Soggy / Soft 濡 Rú                    | Floating, thin, and soft; disappears on pressure              | Dampness; Blood deficiency; Summer Damp                     | Float + thin + soft         |
| Long 長 Cháng                         | Extends beyond all three positions                            | Excess patterns; Liver Fire; Full conditions                | ↑ Length                    |
| Short 短 Duǎn                         | Does not reach both ends; felt in one position only           | Qi deficiency or stagnation                                 | ↓ Length                    |
| ► RHYTHM GROUP — regularity          |                                                               |                                                             |                             |
| Knotted 結 Jié                        | Slow + irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval  | Qi stagnation; Blood stasis; Phlegm; Cold                   | Slow + irregular skips      |
| Hurried 促 Cù                         | Rapid + irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval | Excess Heat; Qi/Blood/Phlegm/Food stagnation                | Rapid + irregular skips     |
| Reg. Intermittent 代 Dài              | Slow; misses beat at REGULAR fixed intervals                  | Organ Qi declining; serious Heart condition; pain; fright   | Slow + regular gaps ⚠ worst |
| ► COMPOSITE / OTHER                  |                                                               |                                                             |                             |
| Tight / Tense 緊 Jǐn                  | Like a taut twisted rope; more tense/vibrating than Wiry      | Cold (Interior or Exterior); pain; retained food            | Taut + twisting             |
| Overflowing 大 Dà                     | Wide, large; like Flooding but without wave force             | Full Heat; early febrile disease                            | Large width                 |

CLINICAL GROUPINGS — MACIOCIA FCM Ch.25

|                                                       |                                                       |                                         |
|-------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Exterior / Interior                                   | Def / Excess                                          | Qi / Blood Def                          |
| • <b>Exterior:</b> Floating, Tight, Rapid             | • <b>Def:</b> Empty, Thin, Weak, Frail, Choppy, Soggy | • <b>Qi Def:</b> Empty, Weak, Frail     |
| • <b>Interior:</b> Deep, Wiry, Slippery, Choppy, Full | • <b>Excess:</b> Full, Wiry, Slippery, Flooding       | • <b>Blood Def:</b> Thin, Choppy, Weak  |
| Cold / Heat                                           | Phlegm / Blood Stasis                                 | Organ Positions                         |
| • <b>Cold:</b> Slow, Tight, Deep, Firm                | • <b>Phlegm:</b> Slippery, Soft, Wiry                 | • <b>Liver:</b> Wiry (Left Guan)        |
| • <b>Heat:</b> Rapid, Flooding, Full, Slippery        | • <b>Stasis:</b> Choppy, Wiry, Firm                   | • <b>Kidney Def:</b> Deep + weak at Chi |
|                                                       |                                                       | • <b>Spleen Def:</b> Weak at Right Guan |

EASILY CONFUSED PAIRS — TEST HIGH-YIELD

| Pair               | Pulse A                       | Pulse B                                     | Key Differentiator                       |
|--------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Floating vs Hollow | Floating: weakens; not hollow | Hollow: floating + hollow center (scallion) | Press center — Hollow feels empty inside |

|                        |                                         |                                             |                                                                 |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Slippery vs Flooding   | Slippery: smooth rolling; normal width  | Flooding: large wave, forceful rise + fade  | Flooding is LARGE; Slippery is smooth but not necessarily large |
| Wiry vs Tight          | Wiry: taut like violin string           | Tight: taut + twisting/vibrating rope       | Tight has a twisting vibrating quality; Wiry simply taut        |
| Thin vs Soggy          | Thin: thread-like but firm at any depth | Soggy: floating + thin + soft; disappears   | Soggy is floating + soft; Thin is just narrow                   |
| Choppy vs Knotted      | Choppy: rough texture; no missing beats | Knotted: beats actually MISSING (irregular) | Choppy = texture; Knotted = missing beats                       |
| 結 vs 促 vs 代            | 結 Jié: slow + irregular skips           | 促 Cù: rapid + irregular skips               | 代 Dài: slow + REGULAR fixed-interval skips = worst prognosis    |
| Empty vs Weak vs Frail | 虛 Empty: soft + weak all levels         | 弱 Weak: deep + fine + soft                  | 微 Frail: barely perceptible — most severe deficiency            |

PRE-LECTURE REFLECTION QUESTIONS

THINK ABOUT THESE BEFORE CLASS FRIDAY

- 1. What are the three essential qualities of a normal pulse (胃神根)? Describe each in your own words.
- 2. How would you differentiate a Floating Empty pulse (Yin def) from a Floating Tight pulse (Exterior Cold)?
- 3. A patient has a Slippery, Rapid pulse in the Left Guan. What pattern(s) should you consider first?
- 4. What makes Regularly Intermittent (代 Dài) the most serious of the three irregular rhythm pulses?
- 5. Name two pulses that are normal findings in certain contexts (not always pathological).
- 6. What is the difference between feeling pulse at three depth levels vs. simply noting "deep" or "shallow"?
- 7. How does Choppy differ from Thin — and what underlying condition does each suggest?

DANCE MEDICINE BRIDGE

Ballroom dancers develop hyperawareness of physical rhythm and timing. Your proprioceptive sensitivity to subtle shifts in music tempo, partner tension, and floor contact maps directly onto pulse palpation — especially detecting rhythm irregularities (代 Dài, 結 Jié, 促 Cù). Mention this in class participation.

YIN / YANG PULSE CLASSIFICATION — CAM Ch.13

| YIN PULSES 陰脈 — generally deficient, interior, cold |                           | YANG PULSES 陽脈 — generally excess, exterior, heat |                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Pulse                                               | Key Quality               | Pulse                                             | Key Quality                    |
| Deep 沉                                              | Interior; pressed to bone | Floating 浮                                        | Exterior; superficial          |
| Slow 遲                                              | Cold; Yang deficiency     | Rapid 數                                           | Heat; >5 beats/resp            |
| Thin 細                                              | Blood/Yin deficiency      | Wiry 弦                                            | Liver; pain; taut string       |
| Empty 虛                                             | Qi/Blood deficiency       | Flooding 洪                                        | Excess Heat; wave-like         |
| Weak 弱                                              | Deep, soft, fine          | Slippery 滑                                        | Phlegm; Damp; pregnancy        |
| Choppy 澀                                            | Blood stasis / def        | Full 實                                            | Excess; forceful all levels    |
| Short 短                                             | Qi def / stagnation       | Tight 緊                                           | Cold; pain; twisted rope       |
| Knotted 結                                           | Slow + irregular skips    | Hurried 促                                         | Rapid + irregular skips        |
| Soggy 濡                                             | Float + thin + soft       | Long 長                                            | Excess; extends past positions |
| Hidden 伏                                            | Deepest; severe Cold      | Racing 疾                                          | Extreme Heat; >120 bpm         |
| Frail 微                                             | Barely perceptible        | Firm 牢                                            | Deep + wiry + hard             |

**Mixed / Context-Dependent:** Moderate 緩 (normal or Damp), Hollow 芤 (loss of Blood — Yin by nature but floating), Leather 革 (Jing/Blood loss), Regularly Intermittent 代 (organ decline), Overflowing 大 (Full Heat)